

Thanksgiving Dinner Timeline

Dinner at 5:00 PM | Serves 8+ with leftovers

TIMELINE AT A GLANCE

10:00 AM	Turkey prep & oven start
12:30 PM	Sweet potato casserole prep
1:00 PM	Stuffing prep begins
2:00 PM	Green bean casserole prep
3:00 PM	Mashed potatoes start
4:00 PM	Final preparations
4:45 PM	Gravy & reheating
5:00 PM	SERVE!

DETAILED TIMELINE

10:00 AM - TURKEY START

- Preheat main oven to 325°F
- Remove turkey from packaging, pat dry
- Place turkey breast-side up in roasting pan
- Tent with foil, place in oven (7 hours for 15 lbs)

10:15 AM - PREP MISE EN PLACE

- Chop 4 cups onions, 3 cups celery for stuffing
- Mince garlic
- Get ingredients organized on counter

12:30 PM - SWEET POTATO CASSEROLE

- Peel & cube 4 lbs sweet potatoes
- Boil 20 min until tender, drain
- Mash with 1/2 cup butter, 1/2 cup brown sugar, 2 eggs, 1 tsp vanilla
- Transfer to greased 9x13 pan
- Top: mix 1 cup brown sugar, 1/2 cup flour, 1/3 cup melted butter, 1 cup pecans
- Cover, refrigerate

1:00 PM - HOMEMADE STUFFING PREP

- Cube 1 loaf bread (12-16 cups), toast in 250°F toaster oven 15 min
- Sauté 2 cups onions, 2 cups celery in 1/2 cup butter until soft
- Add 2 tsp sage, 1 tsp thyme, salt, pepper
- Mix bread cubes, vegetables, 2-3 cups chicken broth
- Transfer to greased 9x13 pan, cover, refrigerate

1:45 PM - STOVETOP STUFFING

- Prepare per box instructions
- Transfer to oven-safe dish, cover, set aside

2:00 PM - GREEN BEAN CASSEROLE

- Blanch 2 lbs fresh green beans 5 min (or use 4 cans drained)
- Mix beans with 2 cans cream of mushroom soup, 1 cup milk
- Add 1 cup shredded cheddar, salt, pepper
- Transfer to greased 9x13 pan
- Top with 1.5 cups french fried onions

- Cover, refrigerate

2:30 PM - CRANBERRY SAUCE

- Combine 12 oz cranberries, 1 cup sugar, 1 cup water in pot
- Simmer 10-15 min until berries pop
- Cool & refrigerate

3:00 PM - MASHED POTATOES

- Peel & cube 5 lbs potatoes
- Boil 15-20 min until tender
- Drain, mash with 1/2 cup butter, 1 cup warm milk, salt, pepper
- Transfer to oven-safe dish, cover with foil, set aside

3:45 PM - BREAD DOUGH

- Shape risen dough into rolls or loaf
- Let rest 15 min

4:00 PM - OVEN COORDINATION

- Remove turkey (check temp 165°F), tent with foil to rest
- Preheat second oven to 350°F
- Main oven (350°F): Sweet potato casserole (30 min)
- Second oven (350°F): Homemade stuffing (30 min)

4:15 PM

- Add to ovens: Green bean casserole, stovetop stuffing, mashed potatoes (all 25 min)
- Bake bread in toaster oven (20-25 min at 375°F)

4:30 PM - GRAVY

- Pour turkey drippings into saucepan
- Whisk 1/4 cup flour into 1/4 cup melted butter
- Add 3 cups drippings/broth, whisk until smooth
- Simmer 5 min, season with salt, pepper

4:45 PM - FINAL STEPS

- Remove all dishes from ovens
- Uncover casseroles
- Slice turkey
- Transfer everything to serving dishes

5:00 PM - SERVE!

- Set out all dishes buffet style
- Enjoy!

RECIPES & QUANTITIES

TURKEY (15 lbs, pre-seasoned)

Time: 7 hours at 325°F (28 min/lb)

Done when internal temp reaches 165°F in thickest part of thigh

Rest 20-30 min before carving

MASHED POTATOES

- 5 lbs potatoes, peeled & cubed
- 1/2 cup butter
- 1 cup warm milk or cream
- Salt & pepper to taste

Boil until tender (15-20 min), drain, mash until smooth

GREEN BEAN CASSEROLE

- 2 lbs fresh green beans (or 4 15-oz cans, drained)
- 2 10.5-oz cans cream of mushroom soup
- 1 cup milk
- 1 cup shredded cheddar cheese
- 1.5 cups french fried onions
- Salt & pepper

Mix all except onions, top with onions, bake 25 min at 350°F

SWEET POTATO CASSEROLE

Base: 4 lbs sweet potatoes, 1/2 cup butter, 1/2 cup brown sugar, 2 eggs, 1 tsp vanilla

Topping: 1 cup brown sugar, 1/2 cup flour, 1/3 cup melted butter, 1 cup chopped pecans

Bake 30 min at 350°F

HOMEMADE STUFFING

- 1 large loaf bread (12-16 cups cubed)
- 1/2 cup butter
- 2 cups diced onions
- 2 cups diced celery
- 2 tsp dried sage
- 1 tsp dried thyme
- 2-3 cups chicken broth
- Salt & pepper

Toast bread, sauté vegetables, combine with broth, bake 30 min at 350°F

STOVETOP STUFFING

Follow package directions (typically 1 box serves 6)

Use 2 boxes for 8+ people

CRANBERRY SAUCE

- 12 oz fresh cranberries
- 1 cup sugar
- 1 cup water

Simmer 10-15 min until berries pop and sauce thickens

GRAVY

- Turkey drippings
- 1/4 cup butter
- 1/4 cup flour
- 3 cups liquid (drippings + chicken broth)
- Salt & pepper

Make roux with butter & flour, whisk in liquid, simmer until thickened

BREAD

Shape risen dough, rest 15 min, bake 20-25 min at 375°F until golden

EQUIPMENT CHECKLIST

Large Items:

- Large roasting pan with rack (turkey)
- Three 9x13 baking dishes (casseroles, stuffing)
- Large pot for potatoes
- Large pot for sweet potatoes
- Medium pot for green beans
- Saucepan for gravy
- Large mixing bowls (2-3)

Tools:

- Potato masher
- Whisk
- Wooden spoons
- Sharp knife & cutting board
- Measuring cups & spoons
- Colander
- Meat thermometer
- Aluminum foil
- Serving dishes & utensils

OVEN STRATEGY

10:00 AM - 4:00 PM: Main Oven

325°F - Turkey only

4:00 PM - 4:45 PM: Both Ovens at 350°F

Main Oven: Sweet potato casserole

Second Oven: Homemade stuffing

4:15 PM - 4:45 PM: Add More Dishes

Fit green beans, stovetop stuffing, and mashed potatoes in available space

Use toaster oven for bread

Microwave: Emergency Reheating Only

TIPS FOR SUCCESS

- Start turkey on time - it's your anchor dish
- Prep all vegetables during turkey cooking time
- Keep casseroles covered until ready to serve to retain heat
- Check turkey temp early - better to have extra resting time
- Label covered dishes so you know what's what
- Have serving dishes ready before final 30 minutes
- Make gravy while other dishes finish in oven
- If ovens are full, keep mashed potatoes covered - they hold heat well